

Teaching Philosophy

Joshua Teye

PhD Candidate in Economics, West Virginia University

jt00064@mix.wvu.edu | jteye.tj@gmail.com | 330-565-8770

I teach economics the way I do research: by starting from a real question, reasoning carefully from evidence, and being honest about what the data can and cannot tell us. Many students arrive convinced that they are “not math people,” and my central conviction is that this fear is rarely about ability. With clear structure and the right kind of practice, nearly every student can learn to think like an empirical economist, to read a quantitative claim critically and reason about evidence on their own. Building that capacity is the goal that organizes everything I do in the classroom.

Research-Driven Teaching

My research applies modern causal-inference methods, difference-in-differences, triple differences, and event-study designs, to large administrative and survey datasets such as CMS Medicaid claims and the American Community Survey, on questions in health, labor, and regional economics. I bring this directly into the classroom. When I introduce a statistical idea, I anchor it in a question students can feel the weight of: how a Medicaid policy change actually affects whether new mothers keep their health coverage, or how we separate a policy’s effect from everything else happening at the same time. Working in R, Stata, and Python, I show students that econometrics is not a set of formulas to memorize but a disciplined way of answering questions that matter. This approach also prepares me to teach across the curriculum, from principles and statistics through undergraduate econometrics, and to involve motivated students in research.

Teaching by Doing

The practice my students value most is watching problems worked out in real time. Rather than reading from slides, I solve problems step by step on the board, narrate the reasoning behind each move, and return to the underlying intuition before generalizing. In my online statistics course (ECON 225), 83% of students rated the way I presented concepts as beneficial, and 88% responded positively to the design of the assessments; their written comments pointed to clear, complete notes and worked examples that made technical material approachable. One student who had dreaded the course called it the best math class they had taken. I treat that shift, from avoidance to genuine engagement with quantitative reasoning, as the real measure of effective teaching.

Developing Analytical and Research Skills

Beyond delivering content, I want students to leave able to do something: to clean and interrogate data, to choose an appropriate method, and to evaluate an empirical argument on its merits. I build courses around active analysis, Peardeck and clicker questions that surface misconceptions in

the moment, “try-first” problems, and students called to the board to complete a step themselves, because reasoning is learned by practicing it, not by watching it. For students who want to go further, I am eager to mentor undergraduate research, drawing on my own experience with administrative data, causal designs, and statistical software to guide them from a question to a defensible result.

Structure, Rigor, and Inclusion

A rigorous course is also a well-structured one. I post complete notes and linked explanatory videos, keep materials organized, and use frequent low-stakes practice and pre-exam review so students meet difficulty while there is still time to fix it. In ECON 225, 88% of students found my instructions clear, 83% found the course well organized, and 82% were satisfied both with my responsiveness and with the feedback I gave on their progress. These supports are not a softening of standards; they are how I hold a diverse group of students, including non-traditional learners balancing work and family, to the same high one.

Reflective Practice

I treat evaluations and feedback as data about my own performance and revise accordingly. My strongest and my hardest semesters have both made me a better teacher: my in-person principles course (ECON 201) showed me clearly that lecture-heavy stretches lose students while active problem-solving holds them, so I am steadily shifting every class period toward participation, clearer board work, and more guided practice. Modeling that willingness to examine what isn’t working and improve it is one of the most honest things I can teach, because it is exactly what I ask students to do with their own learning.

My aim is for every student to leave able to reason with data and to see economics as a tool they own. Helping a student move from “I can’t do this” to working a problem confidently at the board, and occasionally toward research of their own, is the work I find most meaningful, and the standard I hold myself to in every course I teach.